Gifts of the Spirit

The one Spirit gives every believer gifts for the common good and leads us to confess Jesus as Lord; Christians share this while differing honestly over whether the extraordinary gifts continue today.

Main passage	1 Corinthians 12:1-11 (KJV)
Topic	Gifts from God
Version	All views (contested point: Spiritual gifts today)
Audience	adults
Length	about 45 minutes
Status	Draft: written by AI from the library, not yet reviewed by Dave

Suggested timing

Opening	4 min
Scripture	3 min
Background	5 min
Teaching point 1: The Spirit leads us to confess Jesus as Lord	6 min
Teaching point 2: One Spirit, many gifts, for the common good	6 min
Teaching point 3: The Spirit gives as he wills, and love is the more excellent way	4 min
Where Christians differ	8 min
Discussion questions	5 min
Application	2 min
Closing prayer	2 min
Total	45 min

Opening (4 min)

Ask: "If you could ask God for one spiritual gift, what would it be, and why?" Let people answer. Then ask: "How do you know what gifts God has given you?" Today we look at Paul's teaching on spiritual gifts. All Christians share most of it, though they differ about some of the gifts today.

Scripture (3 min)

1 Corinthians 12:1-11

[1] Now concerning spiritual gifts, brethren, I would not have you ignorant. [2] Ye know that ye were Gentiles, carried away unto these dumb idols, even as ye were led. [3] Wherefore I give you to understand, that no man speaking by the Spirit of God calleth Jesus accursed: and that no man can say that Jesus is the Lord, but by the Holy Ghost. [4] Now there are diversities of gifts, but the same Spirit. [5] And there are differences of administrations, but the same Lord. [6] And there are diversities of operations, but it is the same God which worketh all in all. [7] But the manifestation of the Spirit is given to every man to profit withal. [8] For to one is given by the Spirit the word of wisdom; to another the word of knowledge by the same Spirit; [9] To another faith by the same Spirit; to another the gifts of healing by the same Spirit; [10] To another the working of miracles; to another prophecy; to another discerning of spirits; to another divers kinds of tongues; to another the interpretation of tongues: [11] But all these worketh that one and the selfsame Spirit, dividing to every man severally as he will.

Read the passage aloud. Ask the class to listen for how many times Paul says "the same Spirit."

Background (5 min)

The church at Corinth was richly gifted (1:7) but proud and divided. Some prized spectacular gifts, especially speaking in tongues, as signs of spiritual superiority. Chapters 12-14 correct this. Chapter 12 teaches that all the gifts come from one Spirit for the good of the whole body; chapter 13 says that love matters more than any gift; chapter 14 gives practical rules for orderly worship.

Paul uses several words for the gifts: "spiritual gifts" (v. 1), "gifts" (Greek charismata, gifts of grace, v. 4), "administrations" or ministries (v. 5), and "operations" or workings (v. 6). The list in verses 8-10 includes wisdom, knowledge, faith, healing, miracles, prophecy, discerning of spirits, tongues and interpretation.

Teaching point 1: The Spirit leads us to confess Jesus as Lord (6 min)

Paul begins with a test: "no man can say that Jesus is the Lord, but by the Holy Ghost" (v. 3). The Spirit's first and greatest work is to bring people to honour Jesus. Any claimed spiritual experience that does not exalt Christ is not from the Holy Spirit.

Supporting verses

1 Corinthians 12:1-3: Now concerning spiritual gifts, brethren, I would not have you ignorant. Ye know that ye were Gentiles, carried away unto these dumb idols, even as ye were led. Wherefore I give you to understand, that no man speaking by the Spirit of God calleth Jesus accursed: and that no man can say that Jesus is the Lord, but by the Holy Ghost.

John 16:13-14: Howbeit when he, the Spirit of truth, is come, he will guide you into all truth: for he shall not speak of himself; but whatsoever he shall hear, that shall he speak: and he will shew you things to come. He shall glorify me: for he shall receive of mine, and shall shew it unto you.

1 John 4:1-3: Beloved, believe not every spirit, but try the spirits whether they are of God: because many false prophets are gone out into the world. Hereby know ye the Spirit of God: Every spirit that confesseth that Jesus Christ is come in the flesh is of God: And every spirit that confesseth not that Jesus Christ is come in the flesh is not of God: and this is that spirit of antichrist, whereof ye have heard that it should come; and even now already is it in the world.

> *"The design of the passage is to give them some simple general guide by which they could at once recognize the operations of the Spirit of God"*
> — Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on 1 Corinthians 12:3

Handout blanks (answers)

No man can say that Jesus is the Lord, but by the Holy **Ghost (Spirit)**.

The Spirit's first work is to **honour (glorify)** Jesus.

Teaching point 2: One Spirit, many gifts, for the common good (6 min)

"There are diversities of gifts, but the same Spirit" (v. 4). Every believer is given some "manifestation of the Spirit ... to profit withal," that is, for the common good (v. 7). Gifts are not trophies to display but tools to serve others. No one has every gift, and no one has none.

Supporting verses

1 Corinthians 12:4-7: Now there are diversities of gifts, but the same Spirit. And there are differences of administrations, but the same Lord. And there are diversities of operations, but it is the same God which worketh all in all. But the manifestation of the Spirit is given to every man to profit withal.

Romans 12:4-8 (read from the Bible)

1 Peter 4:10-11: As every man hath received the gift, even so minister the same one to another, as good stewards of the manifold grace of God. If any man speak, let him speak as the oracles of God; if any man minister, let him do it as of the ability which God giveth: that God in all things may be glorified through Jesus Christ, to whom be praise and dominion for ever and ever. Amen.

> *"Whatever gifts God has bestowed, or in what various ways soever the Spirit of God may have manifested himself, it is all for the common benefit of the Church."*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on 1 Corinthians 12:7

> *"Gifts and graces, charismata and charis, greatly differ."*
> — Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on 1 Corinthians 12:1-11

Handout blanks (answers)

There are diversities of gifts, but the same **Spirit**.

Gifts are given for the common **good**.

Teaching point 3: The Spirit gives as he wills, and love is the more excellent way (4 min)

"All these worketh that one and the selfsame Spirit, dividing to every man severally as he will" (v. 11). The Spirit decides who receives which gift, so there is no room for pride or envy. Paul goes on to show "a more excellent way" (12:31): love, without which every gift is empty (13:1-3).

Supporting verses

1 Corinthians 12:11: But all these worketh that one and the selfsame Spirit, dividing to every man severally as he will.

1 Corinthians 12:31: But covet earnestly the best gifts: and yet shew I unto you a more excellent way.

1 Corinthians 13:1-3: Though I speak with the tongues of men and of angels, and have not charity, I am become as sounding brass, or a tinkling cymbal. And though I have the gift of prophecy, and understand all mysteries, and all knowledge; and though I have all faith, so that I could remove mountains, and have not charity, I am nothing. And though I bestow all my goods to feed the poor, and though I give my body to be burned, and have not charity, it profiteth me nothing.

> *"All these are to be traced to him."*
> — Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on 1 Corinthians 12:11

> *"A man may possess the best of all these gifts, and yet be deficient in what is essentially necessary to his salvation, for he may be without that love"*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on 1 Corinthians 12:31

Handout blanks (answers)

The Spirit divides to every man severally as he **will**.

Without **love**, every gift is empty.

Where Christians differ (8 min)

Christians agree that the Holy Spirit gives gifts to every believer for the good of the church; that the Spirit leads us to confess Jesus as Lord; that gifts must be used in love and in good order (1 Corinthians 14:40); that God hears and answers prayer for the sick; and that every claim to speak for God must be tested by Scripture. They differ over whether the more extraordinary gifts listed in verses 8-10 (prophecy, tongues, interpretation, gifts of healing and miracles) continue in the church today in the same way as in the apostles' time, and over whether there is a "baptism in the Holy Spirit" after conversion, marked by speaking in tongues. Here are the main views of the five traditions, each described as its own teachers would describe it. Within most traditions, individual churches and believers vary.

Baptist

Many Baptists have historically held that the miraculous "sign" gifts (speaking in tongues, prophecy as new revelation, and gifts of healing and miracles) served to confirm the apostles' message and ceased once the New Testament was complete. God still heals and works in answer to prayer, and every believer receives the Spirit at conversion, with gifts for service such as teaching, giving and helping. Baptist views today vary widely: some churches are "continuationist" and open to all the gifts, as long as they are exercised in order and tested by Scripture.

Key texts: 1 Corinthians 13:8-10; Ephesians 2:20; Hebrews 2:3-4; 2 Corinthians 12:12; 1 Corinthians 12:13

Methodist and Wesleyan

Wesleyans emphasize the Spirit's work in making believers holy and filling them with love. John Wesley thought the extraordinary gifts had become rare in the church mainly because Christians had grown cold, not because God had withdrawn them, and he did not rule them out. The Holiness movement that grew out of Methodism taught a second work of grace, and Pentecostalism later grew from it. Methodists today hold a range of views; most stress the fruit of the Spirit over the extraordinary gifts, while a charismatic stream welcomes them.

Key texts: 1 Corinthians 12:31; Galatians 5:22-23; Acts 2:17-18; 1 Thessalonians 5:19-21

Presbyterian and Reformed

The historic Reformed position is "cessationist": the revelatory and miraculous gifts (tongues, prophecy, miracles) belonged to the founding age of the apostles, confirming their message, and ceased when Scripture was complete; the Westminster Confession speaks of God's former ways of revealing his will as "now ceased." The Spirit continues to give gifts for teaching, serving and leading, and God still answers prayer for the sick in his providence. Some Reformed Christians today ("Reformed charismatics") hold that the gifts continue.

Key texts: Hebrews 1:1-2; Hebrews 2:3-4; Ephesians 2:20; 2 Corinthians 12:12; 2 Timothy 3:16-17

Lutheran

Lutherans teach that the Holy Spirit works through the means God has given, the Word and the Sacraments, to create and strengthen faith. Luther strongly opposed the "enthusiasts" who claimed the Spirit spoke to them directly apart from Scripture. The extraordinary gifts are not denied as possible, but they are not expected as normal, are not a sign of a higher Christian life, and must never be set beside or above the Word. Christians pray for healing and trust God's will; a charismatic movement has existed among some Lutherans since the 1960s.

Key texts: Romans 10:17; 1 Corinthians 14:33, 40; 2 Timothy 3:16-17; Luke 16:29-31

Pentecostal and Charismatic

Pentecostals teach that all the gifts of the Spirit in 1 Corinthians 12, including tongues, prophecy and healing, continue today. Classical Pentecostals (such as the Assemblies of God) teach a "baptism in the Holy Spirit" distinct from and usually after conversion, giving power for witness and service, with speaking in other tongues as its first outward sign. Divine healing is believed to be provided for in Christ's atoning work. The wider charismatic movement in many denominations welcomes the gifts but does not always teach tongues as the necessary sign of Spirit baptism.

Key texts: Acts 2:1-4; Acts 10:44-46; Acts 19:1-6; 1 Corinthians 12:7-11; Joel 2:28-29; Mark 16:17-18

Teacher note: This topic can stir strong feelings, especially for anyone who has been hurt by excesses or by dismissive attitudes. Keep the discussion focused on Scripture and on love (1 Corinthians 13), and describe each view as its own members would.

Discussion questions (5 min)

1. What do all Christians agree about spiritual gifts, according to this passage?

> They come from the one Spirit; every believer has some; they are for the common good; the Spirit leads us to confess Jesus as Lord; they must be used in love.

2. Why do sincere Christians reading the same chapter reach different conclusions about tongues, prophecy and healing today?

> Scripture does not state directly when or whether these gifts would cease; Christians weigh texts such as Hebrews 2:3-4 and Ephesians 2:20 against Acts 2:39 and 1 Corinthians 14 differently, and their churches' experience differs.

3. How can we hold our own convictions about the gifts while loving believers who see this differently?

> By grounding our view in Scripture, describing others fairly, refusing pride or suspicion, and remembering that love is the more excellent way.

4. What gifts has God given you, and how could you use one this week to serve others?

> Answers will vary: teaching, encouragement, hospitality, giving, helping, leadership, prayer, mercy.

Application (2 min)

Find out what your own church teaches about spiritual gifts and why. Ask God to show you the gifts he has given you, and use one this week to serve others in love. Pray for unity among Christians who see this question differently.

Closing prayer (2 min)

Holy Spirit, thank you for giving gifts to your church and for leading us to confess Jesus as Lord. Help us use every gift you give in love and for the common good. Where your people differ, give us humility, patience and a shared desire to honour Christ. Amen.

Sources quoted

Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on 1 Corinthians 12:3

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on 1 Corinthians 12:7

Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on 1 Corinthians 12:1-11

Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on 1 Corinthians 12:11

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on 1 Corinthians 12:31

Every quotation was checked word for word against the library text it cites. All sources are in the public domain.